

real events are possible in the virtual world.

NextMeet, for instance, has worked with Indian and international universities to organise virtual events and conferences. Their immersive 3D environment comes replete with *avatars* that can move around the space, 3D spatial voice, expo halls with banner hosting stands, presentation screens in the conference hall, help desks and networking lounges! VRXtream is another metaverse for events, where you can even buy spaces (stalls) and rent them out, or vice versa.

Healthcare. From training medical students to remote consultation and counselling, the metaverse is expected to benefit the medical world notably—and we can already see fragments of it in use. In a blog post that Microsoft put up last year showcasing their immersive MR platform, Mesh, the company imagined *avatars* of medical students learning about human anatomy, gathered around a holographic model and peeling back muscles to see what's underneath. Hospitals are using MR platforms to help paramedics give first aid to patients, the World Health Organisation (WHO) used AR and smart phones to train Covid-19 response teams in remote areas, and psychiatrists are using VR to treat post-traumatic stress among combat soldiers.

Fitness and training. Maybe, exercising in the metaverse would be more fun! Zippy is a virtual world for runners, where people can run across major marathon cities like Boston, London, Mumbai, and Tokyo, or through scenic environments like jungle trails and beach runs. The virtual environment syncs with the real-world kinematics of the runners using their fitness wearables or treadmill sensors.

If you love fiction, then OliveX could have just the solution to add a spot of fun to your run! In association with award-winning novelist Naomi Alderman, the company has

Block and Tackle

"We're moving from a mobile and cloud era to an era of ubiquitous computing and ambient intelligence, an era that will experience more digitisation over the next 10 years than the last 40. We need that next level of real-time hyper-connectivity between businesses and between consumers and businesses, where data and intelligence flow freely to tackle the challenges of supply and demand." — **Satya Nadella, CEO, Microsoft**

"I don't know if I necessarily buy into this metaverse stuff, although people talk to me a lot about it. You know, when I grew up it was like, 'Don't sit too close to the TV, it's gonna ruin your eyesight,' and now TV is like literally right here (puts his hand very close to his face), I'm like, umm, what? Is that good for you? I don't see someone strapping a friggin' screen to their face all day." — **Elon Musk, CEO of SpaceX and Tesla**

"The next platform will be even more immersive—an embodied internet where you're in the experience, not just looking at it. We call this the metaverse, and it will touch every product we build. The defining quality of the metaverse will be a feeling of presence—like you are right there with another person or in another place. Feeling truly present with another person is the ultimate dream of social technology. That is why we are focused on building this." — **Mark Zuckerberg, founder, chairman and CEO of Meta**

"With digital risks already being high, especially for vulnerable groups, safety risks could be more prevalent in the metaverse. There are numerous ways such risks could be exacerbated in the metaverse. Unwanted contact could become more intrusive. The rise of virtual currencies is another challenge. Finding ways to incentivise better behaviours and reward positive interactions may need to become a bigger part of a safer digital future."

— **Cathy Li and Farah Lalani, World Economic Forum**

developed an ultra-immersive running game called *Zombies, Run!*, where every run is a mission to save the world. You run faster when you are chased by the zombies, and slow down to pick up supplies. The accompanying narration and music set the tempo for your run. What a fun way to exercise!

Or, if it is serious athletic practice that you are thinking about, Ghost Pacer might be of help. A solution developed by runners, for runners, these AR glasses project a live holographic opponent into your field of view, for you to compete with and train against.

Retail. Everyone loves to shop. But the pandemic made us realise that physical store shopping is not something we can take for granted. So, for those times when you want to shop but cannot go out, or if you are too busy to shop hop, then you can turn to the showrooms that are slowly mushrooming in the metaverse. From real estate to automobiles, sellers are building unique experiences to woo shoppers. Real estate agents could give you virtual tours of their properties, you could walk around a virtual clothing store and experience the latest in fashion,

or test drive a car virtually!

Social media. This is one space Meta is betting big on. Imagine what happens when your social media apps become immersive? Your friends from different parts of the world could manifest in your living room as holograms! Quite some time for that level of interaction to become mainstream, but, as of now, we commonly see friends hanging out together in shared virtual spaces.

Honestly, there is too much to dream about in the metaverse. *Avatars* might be living in huge mansions in plush downtown neighbourhoods, driving luxury cars, going on cruises and watching their favourite movies on wall-sized screens. But, in real life, the same people might be living in hostels, having no television, not even a bicycle, and maybe no real friends to call their own.

When one snaps out of the dream, it might be very difficult to come to terms with reality. The huge disparity between the real and virtual lives could even lead to psychological disorders. So, we need to know where to draw the line, as in the case of any technological advancement. **EFY**